

Participant Guide

Welcome

Welcome to Climate Hack-tion! Over 60 hours, students from Australia, New Zealand, and the Pacific Islands will develop practical ideas and prototypes addressing global climate action as set out in the Build for 2035 challenge, ahead of COP31 - the UN's annual climate summit. This guide is the central information hub for participants. Keep it open throughout the event and use the linked platform and community channels for live updates.

1. Event Overview

Event Information

- **Format:** Fully online.
- **Dates:** 02/10/26 - 04/10/26.
- **Working Language:** English.
- **Main Platforms:** Junction (Event hub), Discord (Community & Support), Webex (Live sessions).

Theme

- **Overall Theme:** "Build for 2035" – The goal is to turn one of the COP31 priorities into a practical solution that people, communities, or institutions can test and use.
- Teams build a realistic, working solution that advances one of COP31's priority areas: electrification, waste and methane reduction, resilient cities and buildings, green industrialisation, and broader climate awareness and education.

COP31 Priorities

- **Electrification:** Moving things that currently run on fossil fuels, like transport, heating, or machinery, over to electric power. (Global goal: 35% electrification by 2035).
- **Zero Waste & Methane Reduction:** Cutting how much we throw away, and better managing the methane that waste produces as it breaks down. (Global goal: slow waste growth by 50% by 2035).
- **Resilient Cities & Buildings:** Helping buildings use less energy and helping cities cope better with heatwaves, floods and other climate extremes. (Global goal: cut building-sector energy use by 25% by 2035).
- **Green Industrialization:** Helping manufacturers and producers reuse and recycle materials instead of relying on new raw materials. (Global goal: 15% circular materials use by 2035).
- **Awareness Across All Areas:** Helping farmers and land managers adapt to a changing climate, and making climate knowledge easier for everyone to access. (Global goal: climate-resilient farming and climate education reaching all of society by 2035).

Who Can Participate?

- **Age and Academic Status:** Every team member must be 18 or older and currently enrolled as a university or TAFE student in Australia, New Zealand or the Pacific Islands. Students at universities in EU member states are eligible to join teams from Australia, New Zealand, and the Pacific.
- **Special Eligibility:** Graduates who have finished their degree but haven't had their graduation ceremony yet are also eligible.
- **Citizenship & Registration Exceptions:** Your registration form should reflect enrolment at a university in Australia, New Zealand, Pacific Islands, or the European Union. Citizens of Australia, the Pacific, and New Zealand who are studying outside the region may still be eligible- please contact us to check. If you believe you fall into these categories, please update your registration form. If anything is unclear, you can reach out directly to shelly.amir@gdsi.ie.

Team Size & Rules

- Between 3 to 5 members (teams exceeding this maximum will not be allowed).
- Teams will register nationally as either Australia, New Zealand or the Pacific Islands. Pacific Islands are to be read as including Fiji, Cook Islands, the Federated States of Micronesia, Kiribati, Nauru, Niue, Palau, the Republic of the Marshall Islands, Samoa, Tonga, Tuvalu, Solomon Islands, Vanuatu, and Papua New Guinea.
- EU university students are eligible to join any of the Australia, New Zealand or Pacific teams (no EU-only teams).
- Where there is a mixed-country team, the project should be submitted under whichever country most of the team is from.
- Mixed teams are encouraged. We recommend a cross-disciplinary team, including people with expertise or interest in environmental issues.

Important Information

- Working language: English
 - Main event platform: <https://hackjunction.app/hackathons/climate-hack-tion>
 - Community channel: <https://discord.gg/gasmaDwDXY>
 - Participant support: shelly.amir@gdsi.ie
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2. Before the Event

Participant Checklist

- Complete registration before: <https://hackjunction.app/hackathons/climate-hack-tion>.
- Confirm that you can sign in to the Junction event platform.
- Join the Climate Hack-tion Discord channel: <https://discord.gg/gasmaDwDXY> and review the channel map.
- Read the challenge description.
- Check the team-formation process and decide whether you are joining with a team or looking for teammates.
- Prepare the required collaboration tools, accounts, APIs, and software listed by your selected challenge.
- Review the hacking rules, code of conduct, privacy notice, and partner data terms.
- Test your microphone, camera, screen sharing, and internet connection before the opening session.

Technical Baseline

Technical Baseline

- A laptop or desktop computer with a current browser.
 - A stable internet connection suitable for video calls and uploads.
 - Access to Webex (for closing ceremony).
 - A repository or file-sharing account if required by the submission rules.
 - A backup plan for recording and uploading the final demo.
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3. Platforms, Links, and Communication

- **Event hub:** Registration, official event information, challenges, teams, and submissions

Where: [Junction](#)

- **Community:** Announcements, team formation, challenge discussion, mentor sessions, and live support

Where: [Discord](#)

- **Closing Ceremony**

Where: WEBEX LINK (TBD)

- **Technical help:** problems, submission issues, and urgent event questions.

`#getting-started` in Discord

- **Conduct reports:** private reporting of safety or conduct concerns

Email shelly.amir@gdsi.ie

4. Official Schedule

All official deadlines are published in AEST/AEDT (Sydney time). Australia will move from standard (AEST) to daylight saving (AEDT) hours over the hackathon weekend.

We recommend using [Time Zone Converter](#) to check your local time.

- **Hackathon Opens**

AEST/AEDT (Sydney): 9:00 am, Fri 2 Oct

UTC: 11:00 pm, Thu 1 Oct

- **Submissions Open**

AEST/AEDT (Sydney): 9:00 pm, Sat 3 Oct

UTC: 11:00 am, Sat 3 Oct

- Session: **Submissions Close**

AEST/AEDT (Sydney): 9:00 pm, Sun 4 Oct

UTC: 10:00 am, Sun 4 Oct

- **Closing Ceremony**

AEST/AEDT (Sydney): 3:00 pm, Mon 12 Oct

UTC: 4:00 am, Mon 12 Oct

5. Challenges

- **Challenge title:** Build for 2035.
 - **The challenge:** Turn one of the COP31 priorities into a practical solution that people, communities, or institutions can test and use. Teams build a realistic, working solution that advances one of COP31's priority areas.
 - **Why it matters:** Ahead of the annual global climate summit (COP31), this challenge brings climate knowledge and technical skills together. The goal is not to create a finished product, but to show a convincing path from climate ambition to implementation.
 - **Challenge Tracks:** Choose at least one of the COP31 Priorities: Electrification, Zero Waste & Methane Reduction, Resilient Cities & Buildings, Green Industrialization, Awareness Across All Areas.
 - **What teams may build:** Solutions that make climate action easier to adopt, finance, implement, or measure. Deliverables can be a working prototype/proof of concept (preferred) or a mockup / clickable prototype (accepted via tools like Figma).
 - **Challenge-specific judging notes:** Every submission is scored by the judging panel against four criteria: COP31 alignment, Build quality, Creativity, and Presentation clarity. See Section 10 for full criteria weights.
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6. Teams and Collaboration

- **Team size:** 3 (minimum) - 5 (maximum) people. Teams over the maximum will not be allowed.
- **Represent Your Region:** Your team isn't just competing; you are representing your country/region! Each participant may belong to one team that is registered nationally as from Australia, New Zealand, or the Pacific Islands.
- **Cross-regional rules:** Mixed-country teams are highly encouraged, but the project must be submitted under whichever country most of the team is from. (EU university students are eligible to join any Aus/NZ/Pacific teams, but there are no EU-only teams).
- **Pacific Islands** are to be read as including: Fiji, Cook Islands, the Federated States of Micronesia, Kiribati, Nauru, Niue, Palau, the Republic of the Marshall Islands, Samoa, Tonga, Tuvalu, Solomon Islands, Vanuatu, and Papua New Guinea.
- **Pre-formed teams:** Allowed (you can bring an idea from before the event). Participants are responsible for forming their own teams.
- **Looking for a team?** Participants can post in our Discord channel `#find-a-team`.
- **Teamwork:** Everyone on the team should actually take an active part. Teams should agree on roles, working hours, communication norms, repository ownership, and who will submit

the final project.

7. Mentoring and Participant Support

Mentors will be available throughout the Hackathon - see the Discord channel for Mentor Announcements and instructions on how to access them.

8. Hacking Rules

- **Start Time:** Project work may begin only after 9:00 am, Fri 2 Oct Sydney time (AEST). Research, ideation, and team formation before the start are ALLOWED. You can bring an idea from before the event, but you must start building from scratch when the clock starts. No pre-built code, designs, or assets are allowed (this covers code, graphics, audio, and 3D work).
 - **Outside Tools:** Any outside tools, assets, templates, open-source libraries, datasets, or APIs must be legal to use, and all must be disclosed in your submission (including anything you paid for).
 - **AI Tools:** AI coding tools, code completion, code generation, image generation, and similar tools are PERMITTED, provided you list everything you used in your submission. Teams remain responsible for originality, accuracy, licensing, security, and disclosure of material AI use.
 - **Alignment:** Projects must address the Build for 2035 Challenge. Turn one of the COP31 priorities into a practical solution.
 - **Building Deadline:** Stop building when time is up. Small bug fixes after time is up are fine; big changes or new features are not allowed.
 - **Rights & Conduct:** Everyone must follow the Code of Conduct. Teams must respect intellectual-property rights, partner terms, data licenses, privacy requirements, and security restrictions. Do not submit harmful, discriminatory, deceptive, unsafe, or unauthorized work.
 - **Compliance:** Organizers can ask to see your code if something looks off or to verify authorship. Breaking the rules can lead to disqualification. If organizers ask you to stop, stop.
 - **When in doubt:** ask in `#faq-and-resources` in Discord before acting.
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9. Project Submissions

Submit through the Junction platform by 9:00 pm, Sun 4 Oct Sydney-time (AEDT). (*Note: AEST becomes AEDT at 2:00 am on Sunday, 4 October*).

- **Important:** Submit progressively rather than waiting until the final minutes. High traffic near the deadline can cause uploads to fail.

Required Submission Fields:

- Project name and one-sentence summary
- Selected challenge
- Team nationality (Australia, New Zealand or Pacific Islands)
- Team members and roles
- Problem and target users
- Solution description and intended impact
- Project description/nitch — a written summary of the problem solution and approach

- Project description/pitch — a written summary of the problem, solution, and approach
- Demo video — 2 minutes or less, made during the hackathon weekend (can be a video or slides)
- Project repository or files — Must be a link to your code in a public repository, kept live through judging and until winners are announced.
- Any supporting material
- Tools used — You must list any outside tools, datasets, APIs, and AI coding/generation tools used.
- Disclosures — No prior work; the project has to be built at the event.
- Contact person for judging questions: sharon.offenberger@gdsi.ie

Submission Quality Check:

- All links open without requesting access.
 - The demo focuses on the problem, the working solution, and evidence.
 - The repository or files contain enough information for review.
 - All required team members are listed correctly.
 - The submission is saved and visibly marked complete before the deadline.
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10. Voting and Judging

- **Jury Review:** Every submission is scored by the judging panel against the same four criteria using the weights below. Judges score independently, and scores are averaged.
- **Final Decisions:** The judging panel's decision is final. The organisers reserve the right to resolve any conflicts of interest.
- **Tie-breaker Rule:** If scores are tied, the project with the higher COP31 alignment score is ranked first.
- **National Prizes:** Will be selected by jury review of the highest-rated projects in each country/region.

Judging Criteria

- **COP31 alignment**

Score weight: 30%

What judges look for: How directly the project targets at least one COP31 priority, and its relevance to real conditions. Clear, explained connection to one of the priorities (not just implied). Explains why the problem matters.

- Criterion: **Build quality**

Score weight: 30%

What judges look for: How convincingly the team demonstrates and validates their core idea, whether through a working build or a testable prototype. Core functionality is demonstrably validated.

- Criterion: **Creativity**

Score weight: 20%

What judges look for: Originality of the approach. Creative use of data, design, or technology to tackle the problem. Willingness to try something innovative.

- Criterion: **Presentation clarity**

Score weight: 20%

What judges look for: Is the problem, solution, and audience clear and easy to follow? Is the problem explained in plain language, and are the target users clearly identified?

11. Awards and Follow-up

- **Main Awards:** Winner: AUD \$6000 | Runner-up: AUD \$3500 | People's Choice Award: Product (value AUD \$1500).
 - **National Awards:** Australia | New Zealand | Pacific Islands.
 - **Eligibility:** All teams that meet the eligibility criteria (18+, university/TAFE students in Aus/NZ/Pacific/EU) and submit a valid project according to the rules.
 - **Prize Basis:** Per team. Prize funds will be paid to a nominated team representative, who is responsible for distributing the prize evenly among team members.
 - **Winner Selection:** Main Awards by judging panels; People's Choice Award by participant gavel voting in Junction.
 - **Announcement:** 12 October 2026, 16:00 AEDT, Live Webex VTC.
 - **After the event:** Winners will be contacted directly by the organisers and/or EU agencies.
 - **Conditions:** Cash prizes are subject to the EU's applicable financial rules; where a cash prize cannot be awarded directly, an equivalent in-kind prize may be substituted.
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12. Accessibility, Wellbeing, and Responsible Participation

- Provide captions or transcripts for key live sessions where possible and publish recordings according to the event policy.
 - Make essential information available in written form, not only in live calls.
 - We encourage all teams to take breaks, observe reasonable working hours, engage in respectful collaboration, and remain aware of time-zone differences.
 - By participating, entrants consent to the organisers using their name, image, voice, screen recordings, livestream footage, or demo materials for promotional and marketing purposes related to Climate Hack-tion and the EU-Australia Policy Dialogue and Public Diplomacy Facility, without further notice or compensation. Entrants who do not wish to be featured should advise the organisers at registration.
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13. Code of Conduct and Safety

- Climate Hack-tion is committed to a respectful, inclusive, and safe online environment. Harassment, discrimination, intimidation, plagiarism, impersonation, disruptive behavior, and unauthorized access to systems or data are not tolerated.
- Treat participants, mentors, judges, and organizers with respect.

- Use community channels only for event-related, appropriate content.
 - Do not publish personal or confidential information without permission.
 - Follow moderator instructions and platform community standards.
 - Report concerns through email or Discord chat (@sharon_offenb). For an immediate safety issue, contact shelly.amir@gdsi.ie or sharon.offenberger@gdsi.ie.
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14. Privacy, Intellectual Property, and Publicity

- **Intellectual Property and Licensing:** Teams retain ownership of the IP they create. By submitting an entry, teams grant the organisers a non-exclusive, royalty-free licence to use, reproduce and display the submission for judging, promotional and archival purposes.
 - **Third-party Tools:** Where teams use third-party tools, APIs, datasets or open-source libraries, they remain responsible for complying with relevant licence terms and must ensure they hold the right to use and share that material.
 - **Privacy Statement:** In line with Regulation (EU) 2018/1725, personal data collected during registration (name, email, institution, country, etc.) is processed by the EU Delegation to Australia to organise and run the hackathon. Data is shared only with the delivery partner (Junction), assigned judges/mentors, and the implementing team (GDSI). It is not used for marketing and is retained for 12 months after the event.
 - **Publicity:** Code must be submitted via a link to a public repository.
 - **Confidentiality:** Do not invite teams to disclose confidential or sensitive information in public channels or demos.
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15. Troubleshooting and Escalation

- Issue: **Cannot register or sign in**

First Step: Check the registration window and account email; retry in a current browser.

Escalation: Contact shelly.amir@gdsi.ie with a screenshot and account email.

- Issue: **Want to join a team**

First Step: Review the team rules and post in our Discord Channel under `#find-a-team`.

- Issue: **Submission will not save**

First Step: Check required fields, link permissions, file sizes, and browser state.

Escalation: Contact: shelly.amir@gdsi.ie before the deadline; keep timestamped evidence.

- Issue: **Conduct or safety concern**

First Step: Use the private reporting route.

Escalation: Contact: shelly.amir@gdsi.ie or sharon.offenberger@gdsi.ie

For urgent submission problems near the deadline, publish the evidence and fallback policy in advance. Do not require participants to share sensitive account details in a public channel.

16. Frequently Asked Questions

- **Do I need technical experience?** No, non-technical experience is highly valued! Teams without a developer can submit a realistic mockup or clickable prototype (e.g., via Figma) instead of a working build.
 - **Can I join without a team?** You must register as a team, but if you are looking to join one, you can visit the Discord channel to `#find-a-team`.
 - **Can we form a team before the event?** Yes. Registration is per team (3–5 people).
 - **Can I work on an existing idea?** Yes, you can form a team and bring an idea from before the event, but you must build it during the hackathon.
 - **Can we use AI tools, open-source code, or public datasets?** Yes. Any outside tools, assets, or APIs must be legal to use, and you must list everything you used in your submission.
 - **Which time zone is used?** The hackathon primarily uses Sydney time (AEST/AEDT). The hackathon opens Friday 2 October, 9:00 am AEST. Submissions close Sunday 4 October, 9:00 pm AEDT.
 - **Do I have to attend live sessions?** Not required.
 - **Can I change challenges?** There is only one challenge, in which you can choose from several priorities. Projects can address more than one COP31 priority, but at least one must be properly addressed.
 - **What happens if my internet fails near the deadline?** Submit progressively. Requests for special consideration due to genuine technical failure must be emailed to shelly.amir@gdsi.ie before the deadline. Extensions are at the organizer's discretion.
 - **Will my project be public?** Yes. You must provide a link to a public repository, kept live until winners are announced.
 - **Who do I contact for help?**
 - `#general` in Discord channel.
 - For private contact - `@sharon_offenb` OR email shelly.amir@gdsi.ie or sharon.offenberger@gdsi.ie.
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17. Contact Summary

- Need: **General participant questions**
Contact: Discord `#general`
- Need: **Team formation**
Contact: Discord `#find-a-team`
- Need: **Code of conduct/safety**
Contact: shelly.amir@gdsi.ie or sharon.offenberger@gdsi.ie
- Need: **Urgent issues during event**
Contact: Shelly Amir: 9 am - 5 pm AEST / TBA: 5 pm – 12 am AEST